

Dvar Torah Outline — Hallel (Min HaMeitzar): Gog U'Magog, the Three Assaults on Yerushalayim, the Yetzer Hara's Push, and "עֲזֵי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה"

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman continues learning the Maharal on Hallel, focusing on the "מן המצר" section and how Midrash reads "סבוני" as referring to Gog U'Magog—the archetypal head of the nations opposing Malchut Shamayim as expressed through Israel. He outlines a Midrash describing three escalating attempts by Gog U'Magog to attack Yerushalayim, then pivots to a Zohar-based reading of "דחה" as spoken directly to the yetzer hara. Finally, Rabbi Shulman begins unpacking the Maharal's careful reading of "עֲזֵי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה לִי לְשׁוּעָה," emphasizing that the "yeshuah" is attributed to Hashem Himself, not to "strength and song."

I. Midrashic framing: "סבוני" as Gog U'Magog in Hallel

A. Where Rabbi Shulman is in the Maharal

- Continuing פרק סד on Hallel, specifically the paragraph of "מן המצר."
- Rabbi Shulman notes that a **Midrash** darshens the verse "סבוני כדבורים דועכו כאשר קוצים" as speaking about **Gog U'Magog**.

B. Why Gog U'Magog is singled out

- Gog U'Magog is described as "ראש ועיקר כל האומות"—the head/root of the nations.
- Rabbi Shulman explains the nuance of "נשיא":
 - Not merely "prince" as "king's son," but "prince" as **head/leader of a people** (a "principality" model).
 - Parallel: נשיאי השבטים are leaders, not royal heirs.

C. “זה לעומת זה”: cosmic opposition built into creation

- Rabbi Shulman references the Maharal's broader framework (to be addressed later) of **שבע מידות** and the idea:
 - “זה לעומת זה עשה אלוקים” — each positive spiritual force has a corresponding negative counterpart.
- Gog U'Magog functions as the negative counterpart to a particular divine “exalted kingship” dimension (in the Maharal's system).

D. Gog U'Magog's opposition is ultimately against Hashem's kingship

- Rabbi Shulman clarifies a textual issue (possible girsa) but preserves the main idea:
 - Gog U'Magog fights Israel because Israel embodies **Malchut Shamayim** in the world.
 - Contemporary illustration (as Rabbi Shulman frames it):
 - Some opposition to Israel can be ordinary geopolitical competition.
 - A deeper opposition emerges when Israel represents a **clash over humanity's purpose and values**—a “Jerusalem vs. Athens” type conflict.
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II. Midrash: three future assaults of Gog U'Magog on Yerushalayim (5:30)

A. The Midrash's core claim

- Rabbi Shulman cites: “שלוש פעמים עתיד גוג ומגוג לעלות על ירושלים.”
 - Gog U'Magog will attempt to rise/attack Yerushalayim **three times**.

B. First assault: mass coalition, then collapse

- “פעם ראשונה אמר כל גוים סבוני”
 - He seeks to gather “all nations” to attack Yerushalayim.
- Outcome:
 - They are shattered, as in the refrain “בשם ה' כי אמילם.”
- Clarification raised in discussion:
 - “All nations” need not mean literally all 70 every time; it can mean a massive multinational alignment.

C. Second assault: “להרעיש כל העולם” — rallying the world with force

- “פעם שנית אמר סבוני גם סבבוני שהוא עתיד להרעיש כל העולם”
 - A more intense mobilization, not casual confidence.
- Rabbi Shulman connects this to the language:
 - “למה רגשו גוים” — the nations in uproar.
- Outcome repeats:
 - Again defeated: “בשם ה' כי אמילם.”

D. Third assault: global recruitment of armies, overwhelming disparity

- “פעם שלישית שהוא עתיד לפורש על כל המדינות... להוציא מהם כרוזות”
 - He traverses countries, extracting armies from each.
- This time, Rabbi Shulman emphasizes the Midrash's description:
 - A force so large “עד שלא יהיה ערך ויחס כלל לריבויים עם ישראל” — no comparable ratio between their numbers and Israel's.
- Verse association:
 - “לכך אמר בפעם השלישית סבבוני כדבורים וגומר.”

E. Rabbi Shulman's interpretive question: why three—what are the conceptual מדריגות?

- He suggests the Maharal is signaling **three distinct conceptual levels** (not just three historical attempts).
 - Tentative structure (presented as conjecture):
 - 1. **Ribui (multitude)** of armies
 - 1. **Chazakah/gevurah (power, might)** in the assault
 - 1. A qualitatively different stage where the disparity becomes beyond normal comparison (“אין ערך ויחס”)
 - Rabbi Shulman notes this needs more solid development.
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III. “דחה דחיתני לנפל וה’ עזרני.” — addressing the yetzer hara (7:30)

A. The textual question: why second person singular?

- Rabbi Shulman asks:
 - Why does it say “דחה דחיתני” (“you pushed me”) rather than “דחה דחוני” (“they pushed me”)?

B. Maharal citing Zohar: the pasuk is spoken *to* the yetzer hara

- Rabbi Shulman notes it is unusual for the Maharal to quote Zohar, but here he does.
- Zohar’s reading:
 - The verse is said “לנוכח אל היצר הרע”—directly facing the yetzer hara in second person.
 - The yetzer hara stands to a person’s right to prosecute/oppose and **push him to fall**.

C. Chazal support: without Hashem’s help a person cannot withstand the yetzer hara

- Rabbi Shulman cites the idea (as brought in the sugya):
 - “יצרו של אדם מבקש להפיל את האדם” — the yetzer seeks to make a person fall.
 - “ואלמלא הקדוש ברוך הוא עוזרו... לא יוכל לעמוד” — without Hashem’s help he cannot stand.
 - Supporting verse quoted in the transcript:
 - “צפה רשע לצדיק ומבקש להמיתו” (The wicked watches the righteous and seeks to kill him.)
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IV. “עֲזֵי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה... וַיְהִי לִי לִישׁוּעָה” — what is the subject of “yeshuah”? (9:30)

A. Maharal’s close-reading of the phrasing and vocalization

- Rabbi Shulman notes the Maharal’s attention to how the word “עֲזֵי” is written/voweled (contrasting vowel possibilities).
- Direction of the Maharal’s point (as Rabbi Shulman introduces it):
 - The phrase aims to say that **Hashem** is the strength and song.

B. Key claim Rabbi Shulman extracts: “וַיְהִי לִי לִישׁוּעָה” refers back to Hashem

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes the Maharal’s reading:
 - חוזר על הקדוש ברוך הוא “וַיְהִי לִי לִישׁוּעָה”.

- Meaning:
 - Not “my strength and song saved me,” but rather **Hashem** saved me.
 - The “yeshuah” is attributed directly to the Ribbono Shel Olam, not to the human experience of “oz” and “zimrah.”

C. Deferred material

- Rabbi Shulman concludes that:
 - The earlier part of this subsection requires revisiting.
 - He plans to **redo** the first part next week בעזרת השם.
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V. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman presents a Midrashic lens where “סבנו” in Hallel is read as the end-of-days conflict with **Gog U’Magog**, the “head” of the nations opposing Malchut Shamayim.
- The Midrash’s **three assaults** depict escalating modes of global opposition to Yerushalayim, culminating in an overwhelming numerical imbalance.
- “דחה דחיתני לנפלי” is explained (via Zohar) as speaking directly to the **yetzer hara**, highlighting that victory over it depends on **Hashem’s help**.
- In “עזי וזמרת יה... ויהי לי לישועה” Rabbi Shulman stresses the Maharal’s point that the **yeshuah is Hashem Himself**, not merely “strength and song.”